LESSON NOTES: POIESIS & TRUTH

ARRIVAL (5 MINS)

BOARD Write **Poiesis** before they walk in.

PHASE 1: ἈΝΆΜΝΗΣΙΣ / CONTEXT (5 MINS)

THE READING Read text (student reads once, you read once for rhythm).

TEMP CHECK Gut reactions. Do you like it? **What do you think it is actually about?**

CONTEXT - ICE CREAM SANDWICH To understand this excerpt, we must zoom out to the broader plot of **A Midsummer Night's Dream**. Four Athenian teenagers flee the strict laws of arranged marriage, escaping into the wild, untamed woods.

There, they step into a realm ruled by chaotic fairy magic. A trickster fairy uses a love potion—a magical flower whose juice, squeezed onto sleeping eyelids, makes the victim fall madly in love with the first living creature they see upon waking. The result is a night of hallucinatory chaos: loyalties reverse instantly, friends try to kill each other over newly implanted obsessions, and a man is magically transformed into a donkey. They fundamentally lose their grip on reality.

As morning breaks, they stumble back into civilization and recount this wild, impossible story to **Theseus**, the Duke of Athens and the voice of absolute law and strict rationality. He dismisses them entirely, claiming that lovers and lunatics share a reality-distorting "seething brain." Crucially, he lumps the poet in with them, claiming the poet's eye rolls in a "fine frenzy" to give "to airy nothing a local habitation and a name." To Theseus, imagination isn't magic; the poet, the lover, and the lunatic are identical: **broken brains hallucinating nonsense**.

PHASE 2A: ἈΠΟΡΊΑ – THE QUIZ (15 MINS)

THE HUNT Frame strictly as Shakespeare's **mechanics for simulating a mind bending** or breaking reality. Put Clue Key on board. Groups hunt:

- **LINES 1–2** Find 2: **Alliteration** / **Consonance** ("L" sounds).
  - **FREEBIE** Announce **Enjambment** in lines 1-2 to break ice and trigger immediate writing.
- **LINES 3–5** Find 2: **Hyperbole** ("more devils than vast hell...") & **Contrast** ("Helen's beauty" vs. "brow of Egypt").
- **LINES 6–7** Find 2: **Oxymoron** ("fine frenzy") & **Antithesis** ("heaven to earth...").
- **LINES 8–11** Find 2: **Personification** ("imagination bodies forth") & **Paradox** ("gives to airy nothing a local habitation").

"Okay great, now we can talk about what the poem *means*..."

PHASE 2B: ἈΠΟΡΊΑ – POIESIS & THE DILEMMA (10 MINS)

DEFINE POIESIS Originally meant "making." Narrowed to mean the most unmediated forms of deliberate meaning-making we possess—**specifically speech and acting**.

MAGIC OF WORDS

- **Skateboarding Giraffe:** Speech is everyday magic; it bypasses physics to force an image into someone else's brain.
- **Square Triangle:** Say, "Now imagine a square triangle." Let this failure foreshadow the limits of imagination and the intractability of the problem.

DILEMMA Sacrifice imagination for absolute objective truth? **Vote and argue.**

THE INTRACTABILITY Discuss why both sides are flawed.

- **Truth:** You become hyper-literal like Theseus. You lose metaphor, meaning, and art.
- **Imagination:** You risk becoming the lunatic, unable to verify reality.

THE IMAGINAL Use **cinema lighting** to show how they bleed together. The geometric set (Truth) and the mood (Imagination) cannot be separated.

PHASE 3: ἈΡΕΤΉ – REIFICATION & AUTOPOIESIS (10 MINS)

REIFICATION Flow straight from the Imaginal—point to text's end where abstract gets a physical body. Connect to **Oom Piet** and **Herb Garden**. Poets use poiesis to trap invisible weight of mortality in ink so it survives. Just like characters remembering a sense of being saved (sagacious residue of those who left a mark).

META-LAYER Look at what Shakespeare is doing. It's like the poem is writing itself... or are we discovering it? This applies to *all art...*

AUTOPOIESIS Apply the vocabulary of the English classroom to their lives. Let the room debate:

- **Are you a poem or a textbook?**
- Is knowing yourself an art or a science?
- When figuring out your identity, are you discovering an objective truth that is already there, or hallucinating a character and actively creating it?

THE EXIT Cut discussion right before the bell. Whether discovering or creating the self doesn't actually matter. **The only tragedy is passivity.** Are you actively writing your story/finding your truth, or sitting back and letting the world do it?